

Introduction

A surprisingly large proportion of people profess to have no interest in politics. Yet in conversations in bars and cafés, over dinner tables, and at the water cooler, it's difficult to find someone who doesn't have an opinion on the news of the day. The substance of these informal discussions and arguments is the same as the debates that are held in parliaments and in the media: the best way to organize the society we live in. In short, politics.

Politics affects every aspect of our lives, and whether we know it or not. We all take an interest in the ways society impinges on our freedoms, protects us from harm, or allows us to get on with our lives. Simply by living in a society, we are taking part in a political process – choosing how that society should be organized, governed, and regulated is the business of politics. The rules and regulations, rights and responsibilities, and duties and benefits, are the nuts and bolts of politics; how they are decided and by whom the stuff of political philosophy.

Few subjects – except perhaps sport or religion – arouse such passion as politics. Followers of any particular political party or ideology can show as much loyalty as others do to their local football team, and have absolute faith in its validity. Differences of opinion range from the polite disagreement of the dinner-party discussion, to a clash of cultures and all-out war.

Arguments by politicians and their supporters from all sides of the political spectrum are aimed to persuade us to their point of view, and news stories in the media are all presented from a necessarily biased perspective. Rather than simply accepting the political opinions being touted by those seeking our vote or pushing a political agenda, most of us like to think we can make up our own minds. But in order to do that, we need to be aware of all the options, the thinking behind them and their implications. The ideas briefly presented in this little book will go some way to help the reader formulate rational political views, or at least have an informed justification for the

beliefs he or she already holds and, hopefully, to approach the ballot box with more conviction and confidence. And, of course, to be more persuasive in the debates at the bar or water cooler.